

Parentheses and dashes



SEE ALSO

◀ 88–89	Direct and indirect speech
◀ 96–99	Commas
◀ 106–107	Hyphens
Numbers, dates, and time	118–119 ▶
Abbreviations	172–173 ▶

PARENTHESES AND DASHES INDICATE A STRONG INTERRUPTION WITHIN A SENTENCE.

Parentheses and dashes allow writers to interrupt the normal run of a sentence and insert additional information. Parentheses are always used in pairs around the extra text, while dashes can be used alone or in pairs.

• **Parentheses** can be used around an s to show that there may be **one or more** of something: for example, “boy(s).”

Parentheses for interruptions

Parentheses surround extra information that is added to a sentence. The extra text disrupts the normal run of the sentence but can easily be removed without changing the meaning. Parentheses can also be used to enclose an entire sentence, which is punctuated in the same way as any other sentence.

(which was late)

↖ This gives extra information, which could be removed without affecting the overall meaning of the sentence.

The driver bought a new watch.
(His old one had stopped working.)

↖ This sentence gives more information, but can be removed without spoiling the story.

↖ The period is contained within the parentheses.

The freight train (which was late) [with] lychees (exotic fruit).” After

Brackets

Brackets clarify text within a quotation or provide additional information. The information in brackets is not part of the original quotation.

“laden [with] lychees”

↖ This is part of a quotation.

↖ Brackets show that a word has been changed from or added to the original quote.

Parentheses for clarification

Parentheses are used around information providing clarification, such as an alternative name or spelling, a translation, or a definition.

lychees (exotic fruit)

↖ The information inside these parentheses defines what lychees are.